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THURSDAY, MAY 15, 2025

BREAKING NEWS AT CHICAGOTRIBUNE.COM

State’s congressional domino effect

Retiring Durbin, Schakowsky spark dash for Senate and Chicago-area House seats

By Rick Pearson
Chicago Tribune

The still emerging race to succeed Dick Durbin in the U.S. Senate featuring candidates from within the state’s congressional delegation has created a domino effect — a growing list of contenders now racing for suddenly open seats in the U.S. House.

With the potential of at least three sitting Democratic House members vying for Durbin’s spot and the announcement that long-time U.S. Rep. Jan Schakowsky of Evanston will not seek a 15th term, at least four of the state’s 17-seat House delegation in Washington could open up to new faces.

On Thursday, Evanston Mayor Daniel Biss became the latest but

likely not the last congressional contestant, announcing his candidacy for the Democratic nomination in Schakowsky’s 9th Congressional District, which includes the city’s Far North Side and numerous north and north-west suburbs.

In addition to Schakowsky’s seat, candidacies in recent days have been announced to succeed Democratic Reps. Robin Kelly of Matteson in the 2nd Congressional District that includes parts of the city’s South Side as well as many

south suburbs and downstate areas, and Raja Krishnamoorthi of Schaumburg in the north-west suburban 8th Congressional District. Both Kelly and Krishnamoorthi have declared they are running to succeed Durbin.

Democratic Rep. Lauren Underwood of Naperville is also considering a Senate bid, which would set off a scramble for her 14th Congressional District seat in the west suburbs. And 83-year-old Democratic Rep. Danny Davis of Chicago has yet to announce

whether he will seek a 16th term representing the downtown, West Side and west suburban 7th Congressional District. The primaries will take place in March.

While the congressional turnover for the 2026 election is significant, it’s also been a continuing trend through House elections over the last 15 years.

In 2010 — a Republican wave year in the first midterm election of President Barack Obama’s

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Chicago’s growth spurt

City posts 7th largest population increase in nation, part of a wave that also lifted many suburbs

By Robert McCoppin,
Jake Sheridan, Kori Rumore
and Molly Morrow
Chicago Tribune

Chicago posted the seventh biggest population gain of any city in the country last year, leading a wave of growth that also lifted many suburbs, particularly those on the fringes of the metro area.

The city of Chicago added 22,164 residents between mid-2023 and mid-2024, according to new estimates from the U.S. census. That population growth works out to a percentage gain of only 0.8%, but it marks the second year in a row that Chicago’s population grew, reversing a downward trend in previous years. Demographers say the uptick was probably due to the arrival of migrants, many of them on buses sent from Texas, as well as people coming on their own.

Growth also expanded Chica-



Above: A construction worker passes underneath a piece of equipment moving drywall into a new home being built at Ryan Homes’ Prairie Ridge development on Wednesday in Hampshire. **At top:** Jessica Kennedy, center, and her mother, Joan Zagara, left, along with Kennedy’s three daughters, enjoy ice cream at the Neon Cow on South State Street in downtown Hampshire on Wednesday. Kennedy and her husband moved to Hampshire in 2019, buying a home on more than an acre of land.

STACEY WESCOTT/CHICAGO TRIBUNE PHOTOS

go’s far outlying suburbs, such as Plainfield, which led the region with nearly 4,000 arrivals since 2020, followed by Naperville, Warrenville, Montgomery, McHenry and Joliet. Meanwhile, inner suburbs such as Cicero, Berwyn, Evanston and Oak Park, along with middle suburbs such as Schaumburg and Oak Lawn, have seen their populations decline since 2020.

In Chicago, the growth is a sign the city shows “remarkable resilience” and is a “world-class destination,” Mayor Brandon Johnson said in a statement. He touted several recent formal challenges to census data made by his administration that corrected previous undercounts.

The growth shows “Chicago is leading Illinois in the right direction,” Johnson said.

But Chicago’s population peaked in 1950, and the increase

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“This looks like a continuation of a pattern we’ve had for quite some time. The decline in the inner suburbs, the mild decline in the next outer ring of suburbs, and extreme growth on the fringes of the region.”

— Rob Paral, senior researcher at the Great Cities Institute of the University of Illinois Chicago

Trump links nuclear deal for Iran to proxy groups

Tehran urged to end support for Hamas, Hezbollah, Houthis

By Zeke Miller, Jon Gambrell
and Aamer Madhani
Associated Press

DOHA, Qatar — President Donald Trump said Wednesday he urgently wants “to make a deal” with Iran to wind down its nuclear program but Tehran must end its support of proxy groups throughout the Mideast

as part of any potential agreement.

Trump, who is in the middle of a three-country visit to the region, also discussed Iran’s rapidly advancing nuclear program in one-on-one talks with Qatar’s emir, Sheikh Tamim bin Hamad Al Thani. The American president expressed measured confidence that the U.S. effort with Tehran would “work out one way or another.”

But in comments earlier in the day, at a Gulf Cooperation Council meeting hosted by Saudi

Arabia’s Crown Prince Mohammed bin Salman in Riyadh, Saudi Arabia, Trump made clear he expected Tehran to end its role as the chief financial backer of the militant groups.

Iran “must stop sponsoring terror, halt its bloody proxy wars and permanently and verifiably cease pursuit of nuclear weapons,” Trump told the GCC leaders. “They cannot have a nuclear weapon.”

Al Thani did not directly address the Iran issue after his session with Trump in Doha. But

the emir said U.S.-Qatar cooperation on a broad range of issues was lifting their partnership to “another level of relations.”

“I hope you can help me with the Iran situation,” Trump said during remarks at a formal dinner, urging his hosts to help with negotiations. “It’s a perilous situation, and we want to do the right thing.”

The two leaders, and others from their respective delegations, signed a series of agreements,

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EPA gutting limits on some forever chemicals

Trump-led agency is delaying deadline to reduce others

By Michael Hawthorne
Chicago Tribune

In a rare acceptance of regulations adopted during the Biden administration, the Trump-led Environmental Protection Agency is backing the first national limits on a pair of toxic forever chemicals contaminating the drinking water of most Americans.

But the Trump EPA wants to eliminate standards for a handful of replacement chemicals that appear to be just as dangerous, if not more so.

The EPA’s proposed changes, announced Wednesday, reflect bipartisan political concern about perfluorooctane sulfonic acid (PFOS), used by 3M for decades to make Scotchgard stain repellent, and perfluorooctanoic acid (PFOA), sold to DuPont by 3M to manufacture Teflon coatings for cookware, clothing and wiring.

Based on years of research, EPA scientists concluded in 2022 there is no safe level of exposure to either chemical.

Yet the Trump administration attempted to throw a bone to chemical manufacturers and water utilities by delaying the agency’s deadline to reduce PFOS and PFOA in tap water until 2031, and by gutting limits on four other versions of forever chemicals.

Some of the chemicals build up in human blood, cause cancer and other diseases and take years to leave the body. Others, known collectively as PFAS — short for per- and polyfluoroalkyl substances — threaten human health because people are constantly exposed to them through consumer products, the food they eat, the air they breathe and the water they drink.

Lee Zeldin, President Donald Trump’s EPA administrator, vowed last month to take more aggressive action to reduce PFAS

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INSIDE



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Bears in the spotlight during the ’25 season

The Bears will play at least three prime-time games in the first season under new coach Ben Johnson. **Chicago Sports**

Secretary Kennedy grilled over cuts

House Republicans and Democrats alike questioned staff cuts, funding freezes and policy changes at health agencies. **Nation & World**

